Henry Cooke

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Creative Technology, Research & Development

Tinkerer, prototyper, committed generalist. Glue person, consensus-builder, facilitator. Occasional futurist. Data science lab assistant. AI whisperer.

In over two decades working in creative technology, I've developed a good nose for emerging technologies and how they might be put to use by professionals and the public.

As a technologist, I've built websites, games, 3D environments, mobile and desktop apps, interactive stories, art installations, and many prototypes in both software and hardware. I've experimented with digital storytelling, natural language processing, spatial audio, machine learning and made art from edge-cases of speech recognition and computer vision. I've published foresight reports and peer-reviewed research on spatial audio, UX design, and cultural impacts of emerging technologies.

I have led successful teams both technical and cross-disciplinary — the latter is where my heart is. I've done a lot of design, concepting, and pitching and I am trained in video & audio production.

I've been an independent creative R&D consultant since 2024, helping clients understand novel and emerging technologies through research, strategy, and hands-on prototyping.

Professional skills

Trained Agile Project Manager, Product Owner, and Mental Health First Aider. Skilled facilitator and workshop leader. Empathetic leader, communicator and consensus-builder. Adept at working with creative, operational, management, and engineering colleagues on their own terms, and fostering communication between disciplines. Glue person. Engaging public speaker and precise and thoughtful writer.

Technical skills

Expert in Python and a productive full-stack JS engineer. I can usually pick up whatever stack is most useful for the job at hand, including TypeScript, C/C++, Lua, C#, Swift, Java, TouchDesigner, etc. My experience with AI goes beyond the use of coding agents to building software infrastructure and tooling around LLMs and experimentation with low-end inference hardware in the lab.

Former iOS and Flash developer. Extensive experience with Docker and building infrastructure on most common cloud providers and locally. Regularly work with Raspberry Pi, comfortable with Arduino, ESP32, and intermediate electronics. I'm competent with a soldering iron.

Other experience

I'm committed to building communities, as an organiser of Dorkbot Manchester, a volunteer producer/curator for the Electromagnetic Field festival, and a member of Greater Manchester Repair Cafes. I frequently donate my time and skills to arts projects around Manchester, and I mentor early-stage creatives and technologists. I regularly speak at tech, art and design events around the UK, and I am an occasional guest lecturer at Manchester Metropolitan University and University of the Arts London. I am a DIY printmaker and from time to time I collaborate with artists to help them make technically ambitious or unusual work.

Career history

A timeline of my career and selected projects is available at prehensile.co.uk/timeline

The Freelance Years, Round Two
2025 — present, Creative Technology R&D Consultant

I help my clients to understand emerging creative technologies through a mix of strategy, facilitation, and hands-on prototyping. Projects have included: acting as a Head of Innovation for the MediaCity Immersive Technologies Innovation Hub, building a bullet-time camera rig, consulting on strategic foresight workshops for the British Heart Foundation, and delivering an R&D project on audience tracking technologies for Clockwork Dog. I've spent most of 2026 doing fundamental UX and platform design for a connected play startup, along with content strategy and some early experience prototyping.

The BBC Research & Development Years
2016 — 2024, Senior Producer & Creative Technologist → Lead Foresight Researcher

As a producer at BBC R&D, I designed and led exploratory projects around emerging media technologies, most notably voice assistants and spatial audio. As a technologist, I built prototypes on my own and other projects to get a practitioner's feel for technologies and their possibilities.

As a researcher, I frequently published guidelines and papers communicating our findings. I spent my last few years building futures and foresight practices around the organisation and publishing very well-received foresight reports.

The Freelance Years
2008 — 2016, Creative Technologist

In 2008, my instincts were leading me to the creative possibilities opening up on the iPhone. During this time, I worked on projects in Flash and iOS, including the first app to be nominated for a TV BAFTA and Björk's *Biophilia* 'app album'.

This time was also marked by artistic collaborations. Highlights include work with Dora Garcia and Crystal Bennes, and experimental theatre projects leading to The Body at the Barbican in 2015 — "a seat-shaking, soul-searching techno-futurist experience" which won that year's Oxford Samuel Beckett Theatre Trust Award.

Sometimes these threads came together. In 2013, I collaborated on a magical talking throne for a Christmas event at Kensington Palace, and in 2019 I explored audience-tracking with legendary immersive company Punchdrunk.

The Design Agency Years
2004 — 2008, Flash Developer

I started my London agency career in 2004, making Flash microsites and games. This is where I learned both the craft of creative software development, and agency-standard visual design. I joined Preloaded in 2006, where I made Launchball which racked up over 10 million plays and won a slew of awards, including Best in Show at SXSWi 2008.

Education

BA (Hons) Media Production, University of Lincoln
2001 — 2004

I was already a good coder when I left school, and doubted I'd gain much by studying Computer Science. I was enjoying making short films, and had a hunch that Media Production would pair well with my affinity for digital technologies.

The critical theory and production skills I learned at Lincoln have been useful and evolving parts of my toolkit ever since.